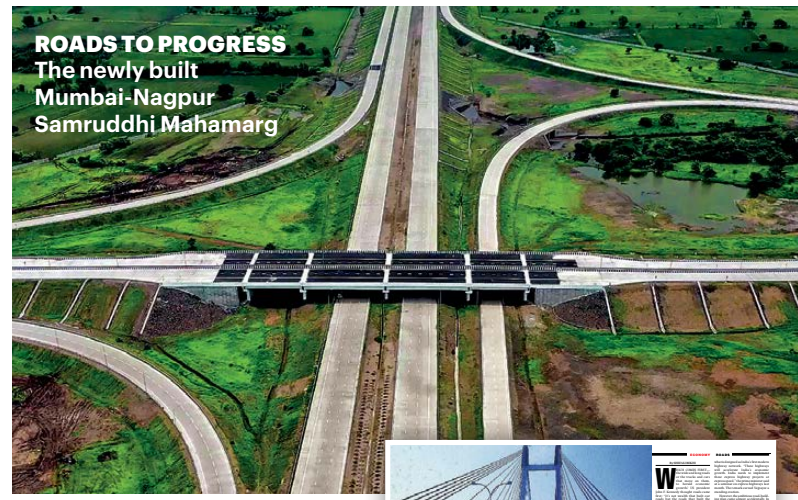
SETTING THE BENCHMARK

- The Golden Quadrilateral revolutionised logistics by drastically reducing travel time and improving the efficiency of freight movement
- It attracted investments and boosted balanced regional development
- Safety innovations like medians, guardrails and improved road design have reduced accidents
- Its successful execution inspired initiatives like Bharatmala and Pragati, institutionalising systems for swift decision-making while carrying out large infrastructure projects
- Modern construction techniques and materials introduced during the GQ project became templates for road-building in India



ROADS TO PROGRESS The newly built Mumbai-Nagpur Samruddhi Mahamarg

INDIA TODAY

The golden quadrilateral project stretches to 6,000 km, with 1,000 km already completed. In the task force project, six-laning has been dropped for the moment, except for a few select stretches. The final cost estimate: Rs 50,000 crore.

–Shefali Rekhi



WORK IN PROGRESS

The PM0 thinks the grandiose project will kickstart the economy, create jobs and enable phenomenal savings in fuel. It only needs to find the money for it.

FROM THE ARCHIVES
Nov. 1, 1999

Roads **Work in Progress**

ects as planned. It introduced several firsts: the use of advanced construction technologies like giant hot mix plants for bitumen, and modern guardrails for safety. For the first time, global consultants were hired for engineering solutions, and standardised road signage became integral to highway design. The project also empowered the National Highways Authority of India (NHAI), setting it on the path to becoming the robust road-building organisation it is today.

To fund the Rs 64,639 crore project, the government creatively restructured the Central Road Fund (CRF), allocating revenue from diesel and petrol sales. This innovation ensured a steady flow of resources, making timely execution possible. The impact of the GQ on India's economy and connectivity was transformative. It reduced travel time between key cities by increasing average vehicle speeds from 30-40 kmph to 60-80 kmph. This not only slashed logistics costs but also boosted trade, commerce and manufacturing. A 2016 study, published in *The Economic Journal*, highlighted how the GQ "stimulated significant growth in organised manufacturing in the districts along the highway network", with output levels growing by 49 per cent within a decade.

The success of this project laid the groundwork for India's ongoing highway transformation. By 2012, the original GQ vision was fully realised, including the addition of crucial diagonal routes during the second phase of the NHDP. Over the years, five more phases have been implemented, further expanding and modernising the network. The Narendra Modi government has carried this legacy forward by reconfiguring the CRF into the Central Road and Infrastructure Fund (CRIF), now managed by the finance ministry.

Under the leadership of Nitin Gadkari, who has helmed the ministry of road transport & highways (MoRTH) since 2014, India has witnessed a surge in the construction of state-of-the-art highways and the upgrading of older roads. In 2017, when the Union Cabinet approved the Bharatmala Pariyojana, a Rs 7 lakh crore highway-building programme, its proposal explicitly acknowledged the GQ as an inspiration—a nod to the visionary approach that revolutionised India's road infrastructure. ■

DID YOU KNOW?

The GQ contract management model paved the way for the Pradhan Mantri Gram Sadak Yojana, which has crossed 80% of its rural road connectivity target